MANDARDEODHAR



SATYANARAYAN NUWAL, 70
Nagpur, Maharashtra

Company
Solar Industries

Net Worth
Rs 14,700 crore

Bang for His Buck

It was a chance encounter with explosives trader Abdul Sattar Allahbhai in Maharashtra's Chandrapur that set Nuwal, originally from Bhilwara, Rajasthan, on a novel trajectory. He paid Allahbhai Rs 1,000 a month to use his licence to sell explosives. His luck turned when the UK-based Imperial Chemical Industries (ICI), which had huge operations in India, made him an authorised distributor. Nuwal shifted to Nagpur in 1984, taking him closer to ICI's clients in the mining sector. Business was good until the growing competition forced Nuwal into manufacturing. He set up a small unit in Nagpur in 1995 with a Rs 60 lakh loan. The very next year, Nuwal procured a licence to make 6,000 tonnes of explosives annually. The company's public listing in 2006 helped it expand, making Nuwal the world's fourth largest explosives manufacturer, with an annual capacity of 4 lakh tonnes in 2021-22, as well as India's largest explosives exporter, supplying to 60 countries.

The other big break for Nuwal came with the Centre's Make in India push in defence. Economic Explosives, a company set up in 1995, makes warheads for drones, hand grenades,

Where he invests profits
In being debt-light

military explosives, warheads for rockets and missiles such as the Pinaka and Agni. This July, the company bagged a contract to supply strap-on boosters for BrahMos missiles. Today, Solar Industries has a staff of 7,500, with two factories in Nagpur—a 2,000-acre one for industrial explosives, and a 1,500-acre plant for defence, and facilities in seven countries across three continents.

–M.G. Arun